Quoting and citing sources

How to bring someone else's words into your essay, explain them, and give them credit. Part 1 is from Purdue University's Online Writing Lab, an excellent resource as you write any paper.

1 Quoting others

From the Purdue Online Writing Lab (owl.purdue.edu).

Using the words of others can be tricky business. You typically only want to use a direct quotation in the following situations:

a. if you're using that statement as a piece of evidence for your own argument
b. if you're establishing another's position
c. if another person has said something better and more clearly than you can.

The main problem with using quotations happens when writers assume that the meaning of the quotation is obvious. Writers who make this mistake believe that their job is done when they've chosen a quotation and inserted it into their text. Quotations need to be taken from their original context and integrated fully into their new textual surroundings. Every quotation needs to have your own words appear in the same sentence. Here are some easy to use templates for doing this type of introduction:

TEMPLATES FOR INTRODUCING QUOTATIONS

X states, "_____."

As the world-famous scholar X explains it, "_____."

As claimed by X, "_____."

In her article _____, X suggests that "_____."

In X's perspective, "_____."

X concurs when she notes, "_____."

You may have noticed that when the word "that" is used, the comma frequently becomes unnecessary. This is because the word "that" integrates the quotation with the main clause of your sentence (instead of creating an independent and dependent clause).

Now that you've successfully used the quotation in your sentence, it's time to explain what that quotation means—either in a general sense or in the context of your argument. Here are some templates for explaining quotations:

TEMPLATES FOR EXPLAINING QUOTATIONS

In other words, X asserts _____.

In making this claim, X argues that _____.

X insists that _____.

What X really means is that _____.

The basis of X's argument is that _____.

2 Citing your sources

Any time you use someone else's words or ideas in your essay, you are obligated to let your readers know that you're using someone else's words or ideas. This is basic courtesy and expected practice. You wouldn't take a funny story that a friend told you and try to retell it as your own — if you got caught, people would think less of you. It's the same thing with citing other people's work — you have to give them a proper shout out. In critical writing, we call shout-outs "citations."

You can cite a source when you quote them in several ways:

USE PARENTHESES

> "Now, we all know that making learning fun and engaging is a good idea, it's sort of obvious, but to be blunt, there really isn't much evidence of it in practice" (Richardson).

Note how the punctuation of the sentence goes after the parentheses when citing parenthetically. The only time you don't do this is when the final punctuation of the original quote is a question mark or exclamation point, in which case you use the parenthetical citation:

> "Now, education is the most important cornerstone of civilization, isn't it? Shouldn't we be making it as engaging and effective as possible?" (Richardson).

In this case, the question mark is a part of the original quote, and thus is included inside the quotation marks.

DIRECT INTRODUCTION

> Richardson states, "Our world and our economy are changing rapidly, and how we approach education needs to adapt."

In this case, you've identified that Richardson is speaking in the introduction of your quote, so you're covered.

> Richardson states that "our world and our economy are changing rapidly, and how we approach education needs to adapt."

If you use the word "that" in incorporating your quote, you don't need a comma to introduce the quote anymore.

3 Works cited

At the end of your essay, your reader might want to know more about your source, may want to go check it out for themselves, or want to fact check your use of the source. A works cited page accomplishes this purpose. There are great works cited generators all over the internet. For MLA style, search for **“Purdue OWL MLA citation.”**

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/mla_style/mla_formatting_and_style_guide/mla_general_format.html